Covid-19 Survey Documentation

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Authors	Ellen Webborn, Gesche M. Huebner, Clare Hanmer
Project	Smart Energy Research Lab (SERL)
Organisation	University College London (UCL)

When the Covid-19 pandemic started and the first lockdown was introduced in the UK, we anticipated significant impacts to the way households use energy in their homes. To facilitate research to understand these changes, the SERL team and colleagues at UCL created a survey for our participants, designed to help researchers understand the reasons for any changes we might find in their smart meter data. This new survey focused on changes to the household and energy-related behaviours.

The survey was sent to participants according to their stated preference for communications (by email or by post). The initial postal survey was sent out on 22 May 2020, with a reminder mailed on 8th June; the initial email survey was sent 27th May 2020, with reminders emailed to unfinished responders on 3rd and 10th June 2020. The postal recipients were encouraged to respond online ('push-to-web') as making unnecessary trips out of the house was discouraged. Surveys were sent to 1711 participants (those recruited in wave 1 as subsequent recruitment waves had not yet taken place) and 1084 Covid-19 surveys were returned (including some duplicates, blanks and households who had changed address during lockdown). Duplicates and those who were at a different address were removed during data cleaning.

Alongside the Covid-19 survey data provided with this SERL Observatory data edition, we also provide a data dictionary spreadsheet linking survey questions and responses with their response codes in the dataset, and copies of the postal and online survey. The relevant Covid-19 files are:

- *serl_covid19_survey_data_ edition{number}.csv*, where *{number}* is the number of the edition, *e.g.* "05"
- *serl_covid19_survey_data_dictionary_edition{number}.csv*

We also provide three versions of the Covid-19 survey:

- *serl_covid19_postal_survey_copy.pdf*: the postal survey sent to households in the first (pilot) recruitment wave
- *serl_covid19_postal_survey_data_entry_copy.pdf*: the postal survey with response codes
- *serl_covid19_online_survey_data_entry_copy.pdf*: the online survey with response codes.

More information about the results of the survey and implications for energy use can be found in our fully open-access journal paper "Survey study on energy use in UK homes during Covid-19" by Gesche M. Huebner et al. (2021). DOI: http://doi.org/10.5334/bc.162